



How AR And VR Can Be Applied To Marketing

Augmented reality (AR) and virtual reality (VR) technologies are making the in-store experience truly fun and innovative. They improve interactivity, level of engagement and offer great excitement



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Can you imagine a bus stop that entertains while waiting? It would make the dull time of waiting more entertaining if the mind could be diverted from the stress of waiting and instead you were made to smile. Pepsi created such an experience for commuters in 2014 at a bus shelter in London. Augmented reality (AR) technology was used to project UFOs, giant robots, balloons and a tiger inside the shelter. The technology made the experience look as if those scenes were actually happening on the street.

Technology is advancing at an unprecedented rate. Increasingly, the real, physical world we occupy seems to be blending with the technological world we have created. And there is no better example of this amalgamation of two worlds than the concept of AR and virtual reality (VR).

But what is AR and VR? What purpose do these serve? And above all, how are AR and VR changing the way goods and services are marketed?

Introduction to AR

AR was introduced in 1974 when Myron Krueger, an American computer artist, built Laboratory Videoplace, combining projectors with video cameras that emitted onscreen silhouettes, to provide an interactive environment for users.

In 1992, American inventor, Lous Rosenberg, developed Virtual Fixtures for US Air Force. It had an overlay of augmented sensory information to improve performance of direct and remotely-controlled tasks.

Seven years later, in

1999, Hirokazu Kato developed ARToolKit, an open source software library for AR applications that overlay virtual imagery on the real world.

In 2009, *Esquire* magazine used AR. On scanning the cover of the magazine, Robert Downey Jr came alive to introduce the issue—tilting the magazine in various directions made models in the magazine alter their clothing, and on checking the magazine after midnight, the reader found content different from what it was in the daytime.

Between 2011 and 2013, AR was successfully used for marketing by such companies as Disney, Coca-Cola and National Geographic for campaigns, and in public spaces like shopping malls and Times Square in New York. Later, car manufacturer Volkswagen used AR for service manuals to provide step-by-step repair assistance, enabling service technicians to see the repair processes on the vehicles.

In 2014, Google introduced Google Glass, the first mass-produced, wearable AR device that made it easy to get digital information simply by nodding one's head. A few months later, Snapchat added the geo-filter feature, which allowed adding geographic locations to photos. Later, they introduced Lenses, a feature that mapped users' faces to add motion graphics to photos and videos.

In 2016, Nintendo used AR technology for the first time for a mobile game, Pokémon GO, which caught the public eye and became highly popular. In Pokémon GO, animated creatures are overlaid in real-world locations, and the player needs to go out and catch these creatures in the wild by travelling around in the real world.

In April 2017, Mark Zuckerberg, chief executive officer, Facebook, added an AR platform to provide digital effects to still



Facebook's Oculus VR system that revolutionised the technology (Credit: <https://swiftinformer.com>)